

PREPARING YOUR RANCH FOR MARKET

A short Texas landowner's guide to the records, repairs, and property facts buyers will ask about.

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TEXAS LAND AND RANCH REAL ESTATE

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BUILDING YOUR LEGACY, ONE PROPERTY AT A TIME.

01 — A Buyer Cannot Value What They Cannot Verify

Start with proof. Keep the story.

Most ranch records do not live in one neat folder. The deed may be in a safe. The survey is rolled behind a cabinet. Well work is remembered by the person who called the driller fifteen years ago.

That is normal. It is also worth cleaning up before the property is shown to buyers.



THE J4 RULE

Do not make a buyer guess. Gather the records you have, name what is missing, and let the right professionals verify the rest.

THIS GUIDE HAS ONE JOB

- 1 Collect**
Bring the property records, agreements, service history, and photos into one working file.
- 2 Walk**
Look at the ground the way a buyer, surveyor, inspector, and photographer will look at it.
- 3 Decide**
Repair what protects value. Disclose what remains. Do not spend money without a reason.

02 — Build the Property File

Put authority, ownership, use, and agreements in one place.

Start with the papers that explain who owns the land, who can make a decision, and what obligations may carry into a sale.

- ☐ Current deed and legal description
- ☐ Latest property-tax statement and appraisal-district record
- ☐ Names and contact information for every owner or decision-maker
- ☐ Any option, right of first refusal, life estate, or purchase agreement you know about
- ☐ Title policy or recent title commitment, if available
- ☐ Trust, estate, probate, entity, or power-of-attorney documents that show signing authority
- ☐ Written farm, grazing, hunting, residential, mineral, solar, wind, tower, or other lease
- ☐ Prior appraisal, BPO, listing history, or written offer that may help explain the property's history

ESTATE OR FAMILY LAND

Do not wait until an offer arrives to learn who must sign. Bring the deeded owner, executor, trustee, heirs, and advisers into the conversation early.

Takeaway: one working file, one list of decision-makers, and no guesswork about who has authority.

03 — Agricultural Valuation

Show the current use and the records behind it.

What people call an ag exemption is often a special appraisal based on qualifying agricultural, timber, or wildlife-management use. It is not a blanket promise that the same treatment continues after a sale.

PLAIN TALK

The appraisal district decides qualification. Your job is to show the history clearly.



GATHER WHAT APPLIES

- ☐ Latest tax statement and appraisal-district property record
- ☐ Recent applications, notices, audit letters, approvals, or denials
- ☐ Lease or operator agreement supporting the current use
- ☐ Dates and acreage for any recent change in use
- ☐ Current qualifying use and approximate acres in that use
- ☐ Grazing, farm, hay, timber, wildlife, or beekeeping records
- ☐ Wildlife-management plan and annual records, if applicable
- ☐ Questions about rollback exposure for the appraisal district and your tax or legal adviser

OFFICIAL STARTING POINT

Texas Comptroller: comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/property-tax/ag-timber/ / Then confirm the tract with its county appraisal district.

04 — Survey, Boundaries, Access, and Easements

A gate is not proof of legal access. A fence is not proof of a boundary.



Walk the property with the survey or plat you have. Mark what you can see. Let the title company, surveyor, attorney, and broker determine what must be verified or updated for the transaction.

PUT IN THE FILE

- Current survey, older survey, plat, field notes, or legal description
- Recorded access, utility, pipeline, drainage, conservation, or shared-drive easements
- Road-maintenance or shared-access agreements
- Known restrictions, encroachments, boundary questions, or disputes

MARK ON THE GROUND

- Public road and every gate or access point
- Fence lines, corners, pins, markers, and crossings you can identify
- Roads, buildings, ponds, utilities, or fences close to a boundary
- Anyone crossing the tract to reach another property

DO NOT GUESS

If access depends on permission, memory, or a handshake, flag it. Do not promise the buyer that it is legally sufficient.

05 — Water and Wastewater

Records help buyers understand what serves the property today.

WELLS + WATER

- Well report or state well record
- Depth, drill date, pump, storage, treatment, and known production information
- Recent service invoices and water-test results
- Shared-well agreement or groundwater-district records, if applicable
- Rural water bill, meter information, or service agreement
- Pond, creek, irrigation, or surface-water documents you have



SEPTIC / OSSF

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| ☐ Permit, approved plan, site evaluation, and installation information | ☐ System type and which structures it serves |
| ☐ Inspection, pumping, repair, alarm, and service history | ☐ Maintenance contract and reports, when applicable |
| ☐ Known location of tanks, field, spray area, or other components | ☐ Local permitting-authority contact information |

OFFICIAL STARTING POINTS

TDLR water-well information: tdlr.texas.gov/wwd / **TCEQ septic information:** tceq.texas.gov/permitting/ossf

06 — Fences, Roads, Buildings, and Equipment

Repair with a reason. Document what stays.



A buyer notices condition, access, safety, and unfinished work. Fix the items that protect use or presentation. Keep a written list for everything else.

WALK AND PHOTOGRAPH

- Perimeter fence, cross-fence, corners, braces, gates, and cattle guards
- Roads, culverts, bridges, low crossings, drainage, and parking
- Homes, barns, shops, sheds, pens, arenas, tanks, and other structures
- Storm damage, active leaks, broken equipment, hazards, and deferred maintenance

WRITE DOWN

- Approximate year, size, construction, utilities, and condition
- Recent repairs or improvements and available receipts
- Items that stay, items that go, and anything leased rather than owned
- Repairs completed before market and known work left for the buyer

OPTIONAL J4 HELP

If fencing, well, septic, or other property work needs a professional look, J4LP can make an introduction to the appropriate J4 company. You decide whether the work makes sense.

07 — The One-Saturday Property Walk

Bring your phone, the survey you have, and one honest set of eyes.

Do not turn this into a month-long project. Walk the place once. Photograph what matters. Write down what you do not know.

1 AT THE GATE

☐ Road name and entrance

☐ Gate, lock, cattle guard, and approach

☐ Public or private access questions

2 AROUND THE BOUNDARY

☐ Corners and visible markers

☐ Fence condition and crossings

☐ Encroachments or neighbor-use questions

3 AT THE WATER

☐ Every well, meter, tank, pond, creek, and irrigation point

☐ Visible leaks, erosion, low areas, or service needs

☐ Equipment labels and report numbers

4 AT EACH IMPROVEMENT

☐ Four clear exterior photos

☐ Condition, utilities, and known repairs

☐ What stays and what does not

5 BEFORE YOU QUIT

☐ Photo of every document gathered

☐ List of missing records

☐ List of people who must answer or approve

DONE IS BETTER THAN PERFECT

Bring J4LP what you have. We will help sort the useful records from the records that need professional verification.

08 — What J4LP Reviews Next

An eyes-on number starts with the ground, not a website estimate.

When you are ready for a listing conversation, J4LP uses The Honest Take to organize the facts and pressure-test what the market may pay.

T

Tour the ground

In person. Boots on the dirt.

A

Assess what moves the number

Water, access, easements, ag exemption, fence lines. What a screen cannot see.

K

Know the real market

Current comps from people who actually work this ground, not a sale from three years ago.

E

An Eyes-On Number

We watch this market every day and set your number on hard facts, not feelings. Whether you are buying or selling, you move from a position of strength.

YOUR NEXT MOVE

Request a potential listing consultation or The Honest Take. No obligation to list. The goal is clarity about the property and the next decision.

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J4 LEGACY PROPERTIES

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OFFICIAL STARTING POINTS

- **Agricultural appraisal:** comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/property-tax/ag-timber
- **Water-well information:** tdlr.texas.gov/wwd
- **Septic / OSSF information:** tceq.texas.gov/permitting/ossf

Educational use: This guide provides general property-preparation information. It is not legal, tax, title, survey, appraisal, engineering, environmental, water-quality, septic-design, construction, insurance, or lending advice. Verify material facts with the qualified professionals appropriate to the property.

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